

Georgia

Georgia is the westernmost of the three republics. About 70 per cent of the people are ethnic Georgians, most of whom belong to the Christian Georgian Orthodox Church. In recent years, the economy has suffered as a result of civil wars and ethnic disputes in the regions of Abkhazia and South Ossetia, which are trying to break away. This has damaged the Black Sea tourist industry.

Gold threads enhance bright patterns.

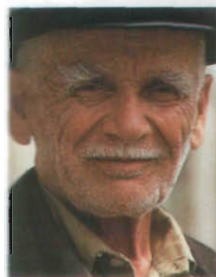


Textiles

Georgia produces fine silk cloth, and mulberry bushes, used to feed silkworms, grow well. Bright cotton fabrics are used to make the headscarves worn by so many of the Georgian women.

GEORGIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Tbilisi
AREA	69,700 sq km (26,911 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,478,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Georgian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Lari



People

More Georgians claim to live for over 100 years than any other nationality in the world. Contributing factors are thought to be a healthy diet, regular exercise, a clean environment – and a genetic predisposition to longevity. Claims for ages over 120 have not so far been proved.



Tbilisi

Situated on the banks of the River Kura, Tbilisi, Georgia's capital since the 5th century, is a multicultural city of 1,200,000. Home to most of Georgia's Armenian minority, it has places of worship for many religions.



Tea and wine

More than 90 per cent of the tea sold in Russia is grown in Georgia, which produces about 250,000 tonnes each year. Georgia also has extensive vineyards and produces excellent red wines.

Armenia

Land-locked and isolated from its neighbours, Armenia is the smallest of the Caucasus Republics. The only way out of the country is by difficult road and rail links over the mountains to Georgia. The people, mostly ethnic Armenians, speak a unique language. The country exports fruit, brandy, and minerals such as copper.

ARMENIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Yerevan
AREA	29,800 sq km (11,506 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,500,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Armenian
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Dram

Cubes of meat are separated by peppers and onions for flavour.

Metal skewer allows cooking meat to be turned.



Food

Lamb is the main meat, often served as kebabs, with a variety of vegetables. Cooks use pine-nuts and almonds for flavouring. Local cheeses and rich desserts are specialities.

Yerevan

Armenia's capital, Yerevan, is also its largest city. Situated on the River Razdan, it is a major cultural and industrial centre. Market traders sell fruit, vegetables, and rich, colourful rugs woven locally from silk and wool.



Farming

Agriculture, mainly in the Aras river valley, employs 30 per cent of the workforce and is the country's main source of wealth. Crops include cereals and fruit such as apricots, grapes, olives, and peaches.



Azerbaijan

The largest of the Caucasus Republics, Azerbaijan also has the most extensive area of farmland. Around 93 per cent of the population are Muslims. Most other people are Christian Armenians and Russians. Naxçıvan, a separate part of Azerbaijan, lies within Armenian territory.

Oil industry

Natural gas and oil are extracted from the Caspian Sea. Pipelines link Baku, which is the centre of the industry, with Iran, Russia, Kazakhstan, and Turkmenistan. Other oil-related industries include the manufacture of chemicals and oil-drilling equipment.

AZERBAIJAN FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Baku
AREA	86,600 sq km (33,436 sq miles)
POPULATION	7,700,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Azerbaijani
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Manat



Territorial conflict

Nagorno-Karabakh, an enclave in southern Azerbaijan, has been the subject of armed conflict with Armenia since 1988. Most of the people here are Armenians, and Armenia claims the territory. A ceasefire was negotiated in 1994, but dispute over the area continues today.



Soldiers on parade, Karabakh



People

Communal drinking of hot, sweet tea from tiny glasses is a typically male ceremony. As in neighbouring Georgia, the Azerbaijanis have a reputation for longevity, and it is not uncommon for people to continue working into their eighties.

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